aligning with neither superpower while maintaining friendship with both and adopting positions on different international issues not because of alignment but on a case by case basis – appeared to be the way out. Michael Edwardes refers to non-alignment as Nehru's 'doctrine of defence by friendship', a policy that appealed to Nehru on both practical and moral grounds.[27] Nehru leveraged India's ties with former colonies to create a third bloc of nations refusing to join either bloc during the cold war. Burma, Egypt, Ghana, Yugoslavia and Indonesia joined India as the founding members of the Non-Aligned Movement in 1961.

Veteran diplomat, Kunwar Natwar Singh, who joined the Indian Foreign Service during Nehru's tenure, argues that while Nehru sought non-alignment he was not in favour of turning it into a movement as, for Nehru, non-alignment was 'a state of mind', not 'a dogma or doctrine'. According to Natwar Singh, Nehru treated non-alignment as 'an instrument' which would strengthen 'forces of peace, disarmament and economic cooperation' and 'provide a platform' for the recently decolonized nations of Asia, Africa and South America.

Like Murty, Natwar Singh asserts that for Nehru non-alignment meant retaining 'our thought, judgement and action under conditions of the Cold War' instead of becoming a camp follower of the United States or the Soviet Union. Being non-aligned, India could stay out of foreign entanglements it sought to avoid while speaking out on issues that mattered. A formal Non-Aligned Movement of states went beyond that by tying India to a group of other mid-sized and small powers, each with issues of its own. According to Natwar Singh, it was Krishna Menon, defence minister and Nehru's close confidant, who 'convinced' Nehru into agreeing to convert the non-aligned idea into a movement comprising several countries.[28]

On non-alignment, Sarvepalli Gopal argues that Nehru was not 'priggishly parading principles and was determined to develop, at whatever cost, a policy of independent judgement of each issue because that was